Uppsala University

Master's Thesis

Thesis Proposal

Applying Transformative Game Design Theory to Competitive Debate

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1 INTRODUCTION

1.1 Brief Overview

Through this thesis project, I apply transformative game design theory and best practices to create a new competitive debating format. This research employs Research through Design (RtD) methodology to develop and playtest an alternative debate format that addresses systematic problems in widely-used formats, particularly World Schools and British Parliamentary debate.

1.2 Motivation

I decided to engage in this labor in order to give back to the community that shaped me most. I have been deeply engaged with competitive debating for 15 years. As a high school student, I was active in the Romanian and international World Schools debating circuits, participating in over 50 competitions and representing my country at the World Schools Debating Championship. Beyond high school, I participated in hundreds of debate competitions worldwide as a debater, judge, club manager, chief adjudicator, competition organiser, and coach. I have spent the vast majority of my time between ages 15 and 25 within the debate world, and even afterwards have remained deeply engaged with the community.

I believe debate is a class of role-playing games with immense transformative potential. I have experienced it firsthand, and personally owe most of my foundational skills and attitudes to my time as a dedicated debater. I have also witnessed as a teacher, trainer and coach hundreds of adolescents and young adults transformed by it, mostly for the better. In the meantime I developed strong opinions on how the transformative potential of most major formats, especially World Schools, is stunted by their design.

1.3 Problem Statement

Based on my fifteen years of observation, participation, and informal conversations with fellow practitioners, I hypothesize that the two most popular debate formats, World Schools and British Parliamentary, whose communities in Europe are deeply intertwined, exhibit the following problematic tendencies:

First, they may push debaters towards value convergence, potentially causing them to become less tolerant of people with different values and diminishing their ability to convince people from different backgrounds. Second, they may teach debaters to speak very fast and with extreme information density, which could diminish their ability to meaningfully support their positions to people not trained as debate judges. Third, they may push communities towards hierarchical behavior that undermines psychological safety.

These observations, while grounded in extensive practitioner experience, have not been systematically validated through empirical research. This thesis therefore serves a dual purpose: to design a format that addresses these hypothesized problems, and through that design process, to generate evidence about whether and how these problems manifest in participant experience.

1.4 Research Question

How can transformative game design theory inform the creation of a competitive debate format that better achieves stated transformational goals while addressing the systematic problems identified above?

1.5 Scope and Limitations

This thesis aims to demonstrate proof of concept: that alternative debate formats can be systematically designed to address identified problems, and that such designs produce observable and articulable differences in participant experience. In particular it will try to demonstrate how a debate format can address one or more of the identified problems without sacrificing entertainment value, competitive appeal or educational potential.

The thesis does not aim to produce robust claims about long-term educational efficacy or entertainment value, as such claims would require longitudinal studies with larger samples than a master's thesis permits. The research will involve approximately 10 playtest sessions over two months with experienced debaters from the Romanian debate community, culminating in qualitative analysis of observational and interview data.

2 BACKGROUND

2.1 Topic Overview

Academic debate formats are games. Following Salen and Zimmerman's influential definition in *Rules of Play* (Salen & Zimmerman, 2004, p. 80), "a game is a system in which players engage in an artificial conflict, defined by rules, that results in a quantifiable outcome." Academic debate clearly satisfies all these criteria: it has rules, participants, winners, losers, tournaments, and scoring systems. Alfred "Tuna" Snider's 1982 doctoral dissertation "Gaming as a Paradigm for Academic Debate" at the University of Kansas, along with his subsequent publications (Snider, 1984), established the scholarly foundation for analyzing debate through game design principles whilst also indexing and robustly proving its many educational benefits.

Empirical studies demonstrate debate's significant educational benefits. Mezuk's research on the Chicago Debate League (Mezuk, 2009) found that debate participants were 70% more likely to graduate and three times less likely to drop out than non-debaters. Colbert and Biggers (1985) noted that debaters benefit in critical thinking, communication skills, and engagement with subject matter. A meta-analysis by **allen1999meta<empty citation>** found significant positive effects of forensics and communication education on critical thinking abilities across multiple studies. More recently, **bellon2000research<empty citation>** synthesized research from competitive forensics, communication pedagogy, and educational psychology to provide a comprehensive justification for debate across the curriculum.

However, I have yet to find any paper that critiques major formats from a game design perspective or presents academic debating as a role-playing game, though Bowman's 2014 literature review (Bowman, 2014) acknowledges related pedagogical approaches such as process drama and simulation as role-playing games. Addressing this gap in literature, applying

game design lenses and expertise to the analysis and improvement of debate formats, is the main contribution to knowledge that I seek to start making through this paper.

2.2 Debate as Role-Playing Game

In the World Schools format, in every debate there are two teams which receive a motion (e.g., "This House Would legalize the possession of drugs"). Teams are randomly assigned to opposite sides: Proposition/Government or Opposition. They deliver alternating speeches as if they were individuals supporting or opposing the motion. Judges listen as someone with no opinion on the motion, expert in debate rules, and averagely informed, deciding who most convinced the character they role-play. The debate ends with the judge ruling who won, explaining their decision and then offering feedback for improvement to the teams.

I argue that debate constitutes a form of role-playing game based on structural and functional parallels with established definitions in role-playing game scholarship. Following Bowman (2010), role-playing games are "co-creative experiences in which participants immerse into fictional characters and realities for a bounded period of time and improvise through spontaneous, emergent playfulness." Debate satisfies each element of this definition: debaters adopt fictional personas (proponents or opponents regardless of personal belief), operate within a bounded fictional reality (the debate round with its specific rules and conventions), and engage in spontaneous improvisation responding to opponents' arguments.

One might object that debate characters lack the specificity typical of role-playing games: they have no names, detailed backgrounds, or complex motivations beyond the motion. However, this objection conflates role complexity with role presence. Role-playing game scholarship recognizes a spectrum of character engagement, from "thin" functional roles to "thick" fully-realized personas (Bowman, 2010). Even in mainstream tabletop RPGs such as Dungeons & Dragons, deep characterization is optional; the rules permit but do not require it.

More importantly, debate's role-playing operates at the level of epistemic stance rather than fictional biography. Debaters role-play as people who believe a particular position, adopting the argumentative perspective of their assigned side. This epistemic role-playing is the mechanism through which debate achieves its educational effects: by requiring debaters to genuinely inhabit opposing viewpoints, the activity develops perspective-taking abilities and epistemic humility.

Evidence for this role-playing dimension appears in actual debate practice. Experienced coaches regularly employ role-playing techniques during preparation, asking debaters to "become" the stakeholders affected by a policy. Furthermore, much debate ethos is summoned also through traditions that role-play 1800s British parliamentary etiquette: bench-pounding, heckling, Points of Information delivered as if holding onto wigs. The format explicitly stages a fiction of parliamentary deliberation.

This framing of debate as role-playing game is not merely taxonomic but analytically productive. It allows us to apply the substantial body of transformative role-playing game scholarship to understand how debate produces its educational effects, and more importantly, how design choices might enhance or undermine those effects.

3 LITERATURE REVIEW

This section reviews existing scholarship across three domains necessary for addressing the research question: forensics pedagogy research establishing debate's educational mechanisms, transformative role-playing game theory providing the analytical framework, and critical perspectives on debate practice identifying potential problems.

3.1 Forensics Pedagogy and Educational Benefits

A substantial body of research establishes the educational value of competitive debate. Colbert and Biggers (1985) provided early empirical evidence linking debate participation to improvements in critical thinking, communication skills, and academic engagement. **allen1999meta<empty citation>** conducted a meta-analysis of forensics and communication education research, finding significant positive effects on critical thinking across multiple studies and methodologies. **bellon2000research<empty citation>** synthesized this research tradition, arguing that debate develops research skills, analytical abilities, and oral communication competencies that transfer to academic and professional contexts.

These benefits have been attributed to several mechanisms. The adversarial structure requires debaters to anticipate counterarguments, developing what **kuhn2005education<empty citation>** calls "argumentative competence." The switch-side practice, requiring debaters to argue both for and against propositions regardless of personal belief, has been theorized as developing perspective-taking abilities and reducing dogmatism (**harrigan2008defense**). The iterative cycle of preparation, performance, and feedback mirrors effective learning structures identified in educational psychology (Kolb, 1984).

However, the forensics pedagogy literature has also identified tensions and potential drawbacks. **merrell2015intersection<empty citation>** examined how competitive practices transferred from tournaments to classrooms can be "problematic or even detrimental when adopted in introductory courses," suggesting that optimization for competitive success may diverge from educational goals. **greene2005lost<empty citation>** offered a critical analysis of switch-side debating as a "cultural technology of liberalism," arguing that the practice separates speech from conviction in ways that may produce "exceptional subjects" whose deliberative skills serve institutional rather than personal ends. While subsequent scholarship has contested Greene and Hicks's conclusions (**english2007debate**), their critique highlights that debate's educational effects are not uniformly positive and depend substantially on design and implementation.

3.2 Transformative Role-Playing Game Theory

The transformative role-playing game framework, as developed by Bowman et al. (2025), provides conceptual tools for understanding how structured play produces lasting personal change. Transformation in this framework encompasses both "a prolonged and sustained state of change" and "a process or series of processes that lead to growth," producing aftereffects that alter abilities and worldview.

Central to this framework is the concept of the "transformational container" (Bion, 1961; Bowman & Hugaas, 2021; Winnicott, 1960), a secure holding environment enabling playful

experimentation and authentic self-expression. This connects to Huizinga (1958) concept of the "magic circle," the boundary separating game space from ordinary life, though contemporary scholarship recognizes this boundary as porous rather than absolute.

The framework identifies several mechanisms through which role-playing produces transformation. "Bleed," the spillover of psychological contents between player and character (Bowman, 2013; Hugaas, 2024; Montola, 2010), can produce lasting changes in player attitudes, beliefs, and capabilities. Hugaas (2024) identifies relevant bleed types including emotional bleed (emotional states moving between player and character) and memetic bleed (ideas, opinions, and ideologies transferring between player and character). "Emancipatory bleed" (Kemper, 2017, 2020) specifically describes how players from marginalized backgrounds can experience liberation through their characters, with positive effects persisting beyond the game.

The framework also emphasizes structural conditions necessary for transformation. Psychological safety is essential for the development of a transformational container; when participants feel unsafe, unheard, or unappreciated, such feelings undermine the conditions necessary for growth (Bowman et al., 2025). The debrief, or post-play processing, is identified as essential to transformation (Crookall, 2014; Daniau, 2016), providing the reflective space in which play experiences are integrated into lasting learning.

3.3 Critical Perspectives on Debate Practice

While the forensics literature generally celebrates debate's benefits, critical perspectives have identified ways in which competitive optimization may undermine educational goals. **greene2005lost<empty citation>** argue that switch-side debating, while developing deliberative skills, may also produce a disconnection between public argument and personal conviction that serves institutional power rather than individual flourishing. Their analysis focuses on American policy debate, but the underlying tension between competitive success and authentic engagement applies across formats.

The phenomenon of "spreading" (speaking at extremely rapid rates to maximize information density) in American policy debate has been criticized as optimizing for competitive advantage at the expense of communicative accessibility (**herbeck1987spreading**). While World Schools and British Parliamentary formats explicitly discourage spreading through style-based evaluation, similar pressures toward information density exist, and the skills developed may not transfer to contexts without expert judges.

Research on debate communities has documented hierarchical dynamics that can undermine psychological safety. **bowman2023social<empty citation>** examined social conflict in role-playing communities, finding that status hierarchies and competitive pressures can create toxic dynamics that exclude newcomers and marginalize certain participants. While focused on tabletop RPG communities, these findings resonate with observed patterns in competitive debate.

3.4 Gap Identification

This literature review reveals a significant gap at the intersection of these three domains. Forensics pedagogy research has established debate's educational benefits and identified some

tensions, but has not systematically applied game design frameworks to analyze how specific format mechanics produce specific effects. Transformative role-playing game theory provides sophisticated tools for understanding how structured play produces personal change, but has not been applied to competitive debate. Critical perspectives have identified problems with debate practice, but have not proposed design-based solutions.

No existing scholarship applies transformative game design theory to competitive debate format design. This gap is analytically productive: it suggests that insights from transformative role-playing game research might illuminate both why debate produces its documented benefits and how format design choices might enhance or undermine those effects. Addressing this gap is the central contribution of this thesis.

4 THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

This section develops an integrated theoretical framework for analyzing how competitive debate produces transformative effects and how design interventions might enhance those effects. The framework synthesizes insights from transformative role-playing game theory, learning theory, and procedural rhetoric, demonstrating how these lenses combine to explain debate's transformative mechanisms and guide design decisions.

4.1 Core Theoretical Constructs

4.1.1 The Transformational Container

The concept of the transformational container, drawn from psychoanalytic theory (Bion, 1961; Winnicott, 1960) and adapted to role-playing games by Bowman and Hugaas (2021), provides the foundational structure for understanding how debate enables personal growth. A transformational container is a bounded space, whether physical, social, or psychological, that provides sufficient safety for participants to take risks and experiment with new ways of being.

Debate creates a transformational container through several mechanisms. The explicit rules and conventions establish clear boundaries separating the debate space from ordinary interaction. The competitive frame paradoxically enables safety: because debate is "just a game," participants can advance positions they might not advocate publicly, explore arguments they find uncomfortable, and fail without lasting consequences. The judge serves as a containing authority figure who ensures rules are followed and provides structured feedback.

However, the container's effectiveness depends on its design. If competitive pressures become overwhelming, if hierarchies within the community become rigid, or if certain participants feel systematically excluded, the container's transformational potential is compromised. This framework predicts that design choices affecting psychological safety will directly impact transformative outcomes.

4.1.2 Bleed as Transformative Mechanism

Following Hugaas (2024), bleed describes the bidirectional spillover of psychological contents between player and character (or in debate, between the debater and their assigned position).

This concept is crucial for understanding how debate produces its educational effects.

Memetic bleed, the transfer of ideas and perspectives, explains how debaters develop epistemic humility. After years of arguing for positions contrary to their beliefs, debaters bleed into accepting that reasonable people can formulate opposing views, that anything can be argued convincingly, and that argumentative power does not equate with being right. This connects to Bogost (2007) concept of procedural rhetoric: the debate system, through its procedures and rules, makes an implicit argument that truth emerges from structured contestation rather than prior conviction.

Procedural bleed, the transfer of physical abilities and habits, explains skill development. The rhetorical habits, speaking patterns, and argumentative reflexes developed through competition bleed into debaters' ordinary communication, producing the documented improvements in public speaking and critical thinking.

Emancipatory bleed (Kemper, 2017, 2020) explains debate's particular power for students from marginalized backgrounds. For students where eloquent public speaking was not modeled, debate provides a transformational container to discover and develop their voice. Being taken seriously as intellectuals, having ideas weighed on merits rather than dismissed based on identity, produces lasting changes in self-concept and capability.

4.1.3 Zone of Proximal Development and Scaffolded Learning

Vygotsky (1978) concept of the zone of proximal development, the space between independent accomplishment and achievement with guidance, explains how debate creates naturally occurring scaffolding. Debaters are power-paired against similar-skill teams, ensuring challenges remain within the zone where growth occurs. Judges provide post-debate feedback, offering the guided instruction that enables advancement.

Following Kolb (1984) experiential learning cycle (concrete experience, reflective observation, abstract conceptualization, active experimentation), each debate round provides concrete experience, feedback sessions create reflective observation space, preparation requires abstract conceptualization, and the next round permits active experimentation. The debrief, which Crookall (2014) and Daniau (2016) identify as essential to transformation, is built into debate through the oral critique where judges explain reasoning, identify strengths and weaknesses, and offer improvements.

4.2 Integrating the Framework: How Design Shapes Transformation

These theoretical constructs do not operate independently; they interact to produce debate's transformative effects. The transformational container creates conditions for risk-taking; bleed mechanisms produce lasting changes through that risk-taking; scaffolded learning structures those changes toward skill development.

Critically, format design choices affect each construct and their interactions. Consider how rapid speech delivery affects the framework: it may enhance memetic bleed (more arguments considered) while undermining the transformational container (increasing performance anxiety) and disrupting the learning cycle (feedback becomes harder to process). Consider how rigid hierarchies affect the framework: they may provide clear scaffolding while

compromising psychological safety and limiting emancipatory bleed for those positioned as subordinate.

This integration generates specific predictions about how design interventions might enhance or undermine transformation. A format designed to maximize transformation would maintain the container's safety while enabling productive bleed and supporting scaffolded learning. This theoretical analysis guides the design process described in the Methods section.

4.3 Connecting Theory to Identified Problems

The three problems identified in the Problem Statement can now be reframed through this theoretical lens:

Value convergence represents a failure of memetic bleed: rather than bleeding into epistemic humility, debaters may bleed into shared evaluative frameworks that narrow rather than broaden perspective-taking. This occurs when the "averagely-informed individual" that judges role-play becomes systematically biased toward particular values, creating selective pressure for certain argumentative approaches.

Non-transferable speaking skills represent a misalignment in procedural bleed: debaters bleed into habits optimized for debate judges rather than general audiences. The procedural rhetoric of the format teaches that persuasion means maximizing information density for expert evaluation rather than connecting with diverse listeners.

Toxic hierarchies represent failures of the transformational container: when competitive success becomes conflated with personal worth, and status hierarchies become rigid, the psychological safety necessary for transformation is compromised. Emancipatory bleed is blocked for those positioned as subordinate within these hierarchies.

This theoretical reframing suggests that design interventions should target the mechanisms producing these problems: modifying judging criteria to enable broader memetic bleed, adjusting speaking norms to produce transferable procedural bleed, and restructuring competitive elements to maintain the container's safety.

5 METHODS

5.1 Design Philosophy

This research employs Research through Design (RtD) as primary methodological framework. RtD positions the design process itself as inquiry, where knowledge emerges through making and iterating upon designed artifacts (Coulton & Hook, 2017; J. Zimmerman et al., 2007). The design process follows E. Zimmerman (2003) iterative methodology, treating play as research. Each playtest generates data informing subsequent decisions, creating a spiral of refined understanding.

5.2 Development Process

I intend to unfold my process through three cyclical phases.

In the first, generation-oriented, phase I will explore potential mechanics and format elements addressing the theoretically-identified problems, based on game design intuition, established theory, and the integrated framework developed above. Brainstorming sessions, design conversations with debate peers, and analysis of existing formats will be tools I will use to expand possibilities under consideration.

In the second, critical scrutiny-oriented, phase I will dialectically evaluate whether candidate designs congruently address problems without introducing new difficulties (e.g., judge cognitive load, time limitations). The theoretical framework provides evaluation criteria: does this design choice maintain the transformational container's safety? Does it enable productive bleed? Does it support scaffolded learning?

In the third, validation-oriented, phase surviving elements will undergo increasingly rigorous testing: firstly informal design conversations with experienced debaters to surface issues; then small pilot playtests identifying unexpected mechanical problems; and lastly a larger playtest with debate community members using structured observation and interview protocols.

These phases spiral until the format demonstrates sufficient coherence, playability, and alignment with transformational goals, or allocated resources run out. I intend to run two small playtests of one debate each, then a larger playtest as a small full-day competition.

5.3 Research Methods

For analyzing the quality of the design I will organize playtests. During these playtests the research methods used will be observation and semi-structured interviews, followed by a qualitative data analysis.

5.3.1 Participant Observation

Following Baker (2006), I will adopt a participant-as-observer role during playtests. My researcher status will be known, but I will participate actively in some debates to obtain firsthand understanding. When observing debates where not participating, I will function as observer-as-participant: present and known but not actively engaged.

Observation will focus on overall debate flow and more granularly on behaviors relevant to entertainment value, rule legibility and adherence ease, and elements distinct from standard formats, judging whether these indicate positive or negative tendencies vis-à-vis identified problems and the theoretical framework's predictions.

Informed by the advice of Spradley (1980), I will record field notes in two phases: condensed and expanded. Condensed notes, taken during debates, will capture key moments, quotations, and behavioral observations using structured protocols. Expanded notes, written within 24 hours of the playtests, will elaborate, add contextual observations, and record analytical reflections. All debates will be audio/video-recorded with consent to enable field note verification and capture verbal content not fully documented in real-time.

Anticipated observation includes approximately 10 structured playtest sessions over two months: two sessions with 1–2 individual debates and one larger session with remaining debates.

5.3.2 Participants

I will recruit debaters for playtests with the aid of ARDOR Muntenia, the NGO managing the debate community in Bucharest and the south of Romania. They will both directly inquire various clubs if they are interested in including a playtest as part of their weekly activity and will issue open calls for debaters in organizing the playtests, especially the small competition.

In Romania, the young adults (not minors) debate community is quite homogenous regarding debate experience, as almost all are senior debaters with training experience. Many of these are students or professionals living in Bucharest. The sample answering my open call will likely be representative in debate experience for the most probable target outside this research: experienced, not novice, debaters.

The majority of Romanian debaters are minors. Ideally, the study would involve minor participants, but ethical guidelines pushed toward this strategy as best alternative.

The target sample comprises approximately 30–40 participants across all playtest sessions, with 12–15 participating in semi-structured interviews. This sample size is justified by the proof-of-concept nature of the research: the goal is demonstrating that design-based interventions can produce articulable differences in experience, not establishing generalizable population-level effects. For Research through Design, depth of engagement with fewer participants provides more actionable design insights than breadth with many.

5.3.3 Semi-Structured Interviews

Interviews complement observation by accessing perspectives not directly observable. Interview participants will be recruited through purposive sampling from playtest participants, capturing diverse perspectives: both debaters and judges (offering distinct perspectives); winners and losers (as performance may affect format perception); and different educational backgrounds (primarily teachers/trainers versus debaters).

Following Knott et al. (2022), the target is 12–15 interviews, sufficient for theoretical saturation while remaining feasible. Sampling continues until new interviews cease generating novel themes.

Interviews will center on game feedback, following a topic guide developed based on the particular design reached and iterated upon. Topics will cover general experience (positive/negative, contrast with other formats, difficulty), intentions to play in this format or use elements of it, and issues related to transformative goals as identified through the theoretical framework.

Interviews will occur within one week of participation ensuring fresh recall, ideally immediately after debates. Duration will be approximately 15–20 minutes, conducted in person or via video call depending on preference, and transcribed for analysis.

5.4 Data Analysis

Analysis follows a design-oriented comparative approach. The primary purpose is not generating generalizable theory but informing ongoing design decisions and articulating how the designed format produces different experiences than existing formats. This aligns with experimental game design methodology (Waern & Back, 2015), where design experimentation

becomes research when "the aim is to understand something generic, some more fundamental aspect of game design."

5.4.1 Iterative Design Analysis

Between playtest sessions, I will conduct rapid analysis focused on actionable design insights, questioning three core points: What mechanics, rules, dynamics worked, produced intended effects and should be preserved or amplified? What did not work, either by failing to address target problems or by causing confusion, disengagement or unintended consequences? What surprised me and how, and do these suggest new opportunities?

This rapid analysis follows directly from expanded field notes, identifying specific design modifications for next iterations and noting questions or hypotheses for subsequent sessions, treating playtesting as "play as research" (E. Zimmerman, 2003) with each session generating questions informing the next design cycle.

5.4.2 Final Comparative Analysis

After the final playtest, I will conduct systematic comparative analysis of the complete dataset (field notes, observations, interview transcripts, design memos) in three phases.

In the first phase of initial coding, following the advice of Lankoski and Björk (2015), I will identify and label data segments describing participant experiences, behaviors, and reflections. Codes will be descriptive rather than interpretive, capturing what happened rather than meaning.

In the second phase of comparative code analysis, I will organize descriptive codes into comparative categories structured around the theoretical framework's constructs. Within each category, I will code for continuity (experiences similar to traditional formats), difference (experiences diverging from traditional formats), and novelty (experiences unique to the designed format).

In the last phase I will articulate design principles producing identified effects, connecting observed effects to specific format mechanics: Which rules, structures, or dynamics seem responsible? Why might these mechanics produce these effects? Drawing on formal game analysis techniques (Lankoski & Björk, 2015), this examines relationships between game components (rules, roles, constraints), player actions (what the format enables and constrains), and goals (what players are incentivized to pursue). The aim is producing not just observations of difference but explanatory accounts informing future format design.

This approach is designed for proof-of-concept research. The analysis can demonstrate: (a) the designed format produces experiences participants describe as different from traditional formats; (b) specific format mechanics appear connected to specific experiential differences; and (c) these differences align with intended transformative design goals.

The analysis cannot demonstrate that differences persist over time or across contexts, that educational or transformative outcomes are superior rather than different, or that findings generalize beyond the specific participant population. Such claims would require longitudinal, larger-scale research exceeding thesis scope. This limitation is appropriate for Research through Design, where contribution lies in demonstrating that systematic design can address identified problems and in articulating design principles meriting further investigation

or usage.

5.5 Ethical Considerations

This research adheres to Uppsala University's ethical guidelines for research involving human participants. All playtest participants will be informed of the purpose and context, how data will be gathered, stored, and analyzed, both during and after recruitment. All will be able to offer and retract consent, granularly or wholesale, to participation in every process part and to data being collected, stored, or used. Peers whose input I use in developing this format will be informed of context and credited. All data will be stored securely in encrypted Microsoft OneDrive offered by Uppsala University, separated by content type, and deleted once thesis development and presentation is complete. All data will be anonymized and not publicly available.

To ensure psychological safety, the rigorous ethical standards imposed by the ARDOR Ethical Guide and ARDOR Trainer Safety Guide will be followed. Debate topics will avoid personal trauma topics and debaters will be able to refuse to engage with motions. Debaters will be able to always talk to a third-party equity officer regarding emotional safety issues and report abusive or distressing behavior. During debates, all debaters will be able to exit without explanation.

Beyond these, all participants will have pre-session briefing and post-session debrief providing chances to address potential distressing elements before activity and discuss experience afterwards.

5.6 Positionality and Reflexivity

I approach this research as a complete community member (Adler & Adler, 1987). My fifteen years in competitive debate have shaped not only my knowledge but my values, assumptions, and emotional investments. This informs several positions that I must acknowledge and address.

First, I bring insider knowledge that enables nuanced understanding of implicit norms, unspoken hierarchies, and lived competition experience. This knowledge is a research resource: I can recognize subtle phenomena that outsiders might miss, interpret participant statements against community context, and engage participants as a peer. However, this familiarity may also create blind spots, assumptions so deeply held that I fail to question them.

Second, I acknowledge my reformist motivation. This research emerges from genuine frustration with existing formats. This predisposes me toward confirming my critique and positions this research as holding rhetorical value within the debate community. I must remain alert to evidence complicating my assumptions and must be transparent throughout about my starting position.

Third, I recognize the novelty of my disciplinary lens. I approach debate through game design and transformative play frameworks rather than the educational, civic, or rhetorical lenses most common in forensics scholarship. This privileges certain questions (How do mechanics shape experience? What transformations does play enable?) while potentially obscuring others.

Fourth, I must address power dynamics created by my status as former Team Romania coach, ARDOR board member, and overall successful debater. Some participants may wish to please or impress me; others to challenge or diminish my work. Former students, colleagues, or mentees may feel particular pressure to provide supportive feedback.

My relationship with the specific formats being critiqued also requires reflection. I achieved competitive success within World Schools and British Parliamentary debate. This creates tension: does my critique emerge from someone who succeeded despite format limitations, or someone shaped by those limitations in ways I cannot fully perceive? My positive experiences with these formats may bias me toward underestimating their problems; alternatively, my deep familiarity may enable recognition of subtle issues invisible to casual participants.

Several practices will support ongoing reflexive awareness. Throughout data collection and analysis, I will maintain a reflexive journal documenting emotions, realizations, decisions, and dilemmas. Following Knott et al. (2022), each interview will be followed by a reflexive note. During analysis, I will actively seek data contradicting expectations or emerging interpretations, trying not to marginalize negative cases. Regular discussion with my thesis supervisor and fellow researchers from within and outside the debate community will provide external perspectives.

Given the likelihood some participants will be known to me, specific strategies will address relationship-related bias. Recruitment will be externalized to ARDOR Muntenia staff to include debaters I have not previously coached or worked with directly. During analysis, I will flag data from participants with whom I have close prior relationships and consider whether relationship dynamics may have influenced responses. Where possible, I will triangulate self-report data with observational data less susceptible to social desirability effects.

Complete elimination of positionality effects is neither possible nor desirable, as my insider knowledge and reputation are also resources enabling this research.

6 Conclusion

Alfred "Tuna" Snider was first to recognize debate as a game and to apply play logic to its analysis, doing this way before game design was a recognized discipline. Through his career as a teacher and scholar he championed the transformative power of playing this game with joy, passion and determination. Although many of his students, one of whom I was very privileged to be, did continue his work in fields such as civics, education, rhetoric and his own specialty of forensics, none used game-design know-how to answer the question that most naturally flows from his argument that debate is a game: how can we make it a better game?

This thesis seeks to begin answering that question. By applying transformative game design theory to competitive debate, it aims to demonstrate that systematic design interventions can address identified problems while preserving debate's documented benefits. The contribution lies not in producing a finished format but in establishing proof of concept: that the intersection of game design scholarship and forensics pedagogy offers productive tools for format improvement, and in articulating design principles worthy of further development and investigation.

Timeline Annex

- **01–15 January:** Thesis proposal refining
- **16–31 January:** Design of the new format, conversations with fellow senior debaters and with other game designers; organizing the first playtest
- **01–15 February:** First pilot playtest, first interviews, announcing the mini-competition and opening registration, iteration on the game design
- **16–28 February:** Second pilot playtest and interviews, finishing registrations for the mini-competition, iteration on the game design
- **01–20 March:** Mini-competition extensive playtests, running all remaining interviews
- **21 March–01 May:** Data analysis, further theoretical inquiries, thesis writing

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